Equity and Access

This session examined how AI may both bridge and deepen equity gaps in higher education. Faculty explored financial, awareness, bias, and adoption disparities and discussed ways to ensure equitable access to AI tools, training, and outcomes across all student populations.

Key Findings from Faculty Discussion

- **Access and Financial Disparity:** Free vs. premium AI models create a two-tiered learning system. Students with financial means gain access to higher-performing models, leaving others behind.
- **Awareness Gap:** Even when institutions provide licensed tools (like Microsoft Copilot), students often remain unaware of these resources. Faculty suggested incorporating AI literacy sessions into orientation or short courses to increase equitable awareness.
- **Bias Gap:** Verifying AI outputs is a critical skill for mitigating bias, but some questioned whether students currently possess the critical literacy to detect inaccuracies or cultural bias in AI-generated content.
- **Who Gets Left Behind:** Historically marginalized populations and students entering entry-level jobs risk being most disadvantaged if AI becomes essential for academic and professional success.
- **Who Benefits:** Faculty noted that the main beneficiaries are large technology firms and AI developers, while it remains unclear whether educational institutions and students will share proportional benefits.
- **Leveling or Tilting the Field:** Whether AI levels or tilts the playing field depends on how educators design lessons that expand curriculum access and create opportunities for students to advocate for their own needs.

References

Catalyzing Equity in STEM Teams: Harnessing Generative AI (PMC, 2024) (link)
Generative AI can facilitate inclusion and equal participation in team-based STEM learning, allowing diverse voices to be heard and reducing barriers to collaboration.

Artificial Intelligence: An Untapped Opportunity for Equity in STEM Education (MDPI, 2025) (link)
By aligning AI tools with Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles, educators can personalize instruction, improve accessibility, and close achievement gaps across diverse STEM learners.

Bridging Educational Equity Gaps: AI Tools for Students with Disabilities in STEM (ASEE, 2024) (link)
AI-driven adaptive tools can enhance accessibility for students with disabilities in STEM, improving engagement, confidence, and comprehension through personalized learning support.

Generative AI in Higher Education: Evidence from an Elite College (arXiv, 2025) (link)
Adoption of AI tools varies widely across disciplines and demographics, suggesting that AI may unintentionally reinforce existing educational inequalities.

Decoding Generative AI and Equity in Higher Education (WCET, 2024) (link)
Unequal access to premium AI tools such as ChatGPT Plus can exacerbate the digital divide among students, with wealthier users gaining higher-quality educational support.

Equity and Addressing Concerns in Teaching and Learning with AI (Frontiers, 2024) (link)
AI may amplify systemic inequities in higher education, particularly for minoritized groups who already face barriers to technology access and digital literacy.

EQUITY and ACCESS

hour session (or mini-course) in orientation

- ACCESS GAP: free vs Premium
- AWARENESS GAP: many are unaware of what school is providing
- BIAS GAP : AI exacerbates bias - yes, vetting/verification is necessary!

Do our students have the skill of ID'ing credible + reliable resources?

- Adoption GAP : 91% in natural science vs 57% in languages

How is this being used in these areas?

. Who gets left behind when AI becomes essential for success?

Historically marginalized populations (free vs premium) $$

entry-level jobs?

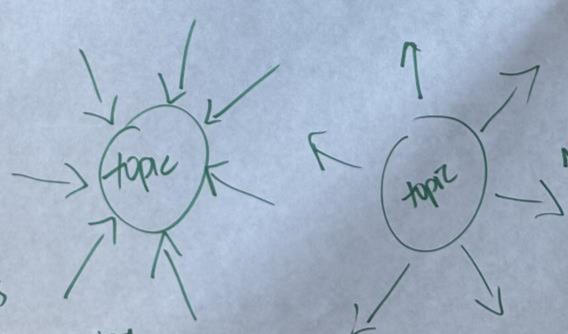
. Who benefits?

The developers / big companies

. Are we leveling / tilting the field?

Depending on how we are using AI to develop lessons that provide students deeper access to curriculum...

Are we allowing space for student advocacy for themselves ...



Many roads lead to understanding

Many ways for S. to show mastery